

Italy



A Mediterranean country that once controlled an empire stretching from Scotland to Egypt.

753 BCE The traditional date for the founding of Rome by Romulus and Remus.

510 BCE Rome becomes a republic after the expulsion of king Tarquinius Superbus; over the next two centuries the military might of Rome gradually conquers the surrounding peoples in central Italy.

390 BCE Gauls capture Rome and burn most of it to the ground. After they leave, the Romans rebuild their city and protect it with the Servian Wall.

272 BCE After the conquest of Taranto in the south, all of central and southern Italy is united under Roman rule.

264–146 BCE Rome fights for domination of the western Mediterranean with Carthage, a Phoenician city in North Africa, which is eventually defeated in the three lengthy Punic Wars (264–241 BCE, 218–202 BCE, 149–146 BCE); Rome proceeds to conquer Greece and most of the Mediterranean region.

49–44 BCE Julius Caesar is dictator of Rome.

27 BCE Octavian, adoptive son of Caesar, is proclaimed emperor, or supreme commander, thereby effectively destroying the institutions of the republic and inaugurating imperial rule. In 23 BCE he is awarded the title Augustus (“the deeply respected one”) by the Senate.

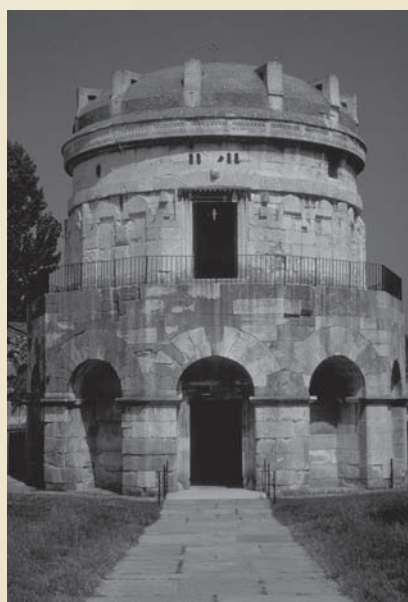
79 CE Mount Vesuvius erupts, burying the two cities of Pompeii and Herculaneum.

117–138 During the reign of Emperor Hadrian, the Roman Empire includes the Iberian peninsula, Gaul (present-day France), Britannia (present-day Britain), Greece, all of central Europe south of the Rhine and Danube rivers, Asia Minor, Armenia, Syria (including Palestine), Egypt, and North Africa.

284–305 Emperor Diocletian sets up the four-man Tetrarchy to govern in order to make it easier to govern the empire; he also increases the size and efficiency of the army to deal with the growing external threat. During his reign, the empire is both prosperous and peaceful.

306–37 Emperor Constantine reunites the empire.

313 Religious freedom is guaranteed throughout the empire by the Edict of Milan; Christianity becomes the dominant religion and Rome becomes the seat of the papacy. Emperor Constantine also establishes a new eastern capital of the empire at Constantinople.



The civilized invaders

Many of the tribes that invaded the Roman Empire quickly absorbed Roman culture and beliefs. This mausoleum was built in Ravenna by the Ostrogoths for their leader Theodoric.

363 After the death of the Emperor Julian, who tried but failed to reintroduce the old Roman pagan gods, Christianity returns as the main religion.

375 As the Huns continue to press westward, the Visigoths cross the Danube into the empire. After they defeat and kill Emperor Valens at Adrianople in 378, they are allowed to settle in what is now Bulgaria.

395 Visigoths rebel under their leader Alaric, and raid the Balkans and northern Italy. After the death of Theodosius I, the empire is now permanently split between eastern and western halves.

410 Visigoths sack Rome.

418 The Visigoths establish an independent kingdom in Aquitaine in Gaul, and large parts of Spain are now under Vandal, Alan, or Suevi control. By the time the Vandals cross to North Africa in 1429 and capture Carthage, the western Roman Empire is on the point of collapse. Many of these invading tribes, however, are already Christian or soon convert to Christianity, adopting Roman customs and culture and taking over many of the institutions and practices of the empire.

476 The Roman Empire collapses in the west as the last emperor, Romulus Augustulus, abdicates, although the empire continues to survive in the east.

492 Italy falls to the Ostrogoths. Theodoric founds Kingdom of Italy with its capital at Ravenna.

533–53 Byzantine emperor Justinian I achieves reconquest of Italy, but at great cost to surviving Roman cities.

568 Italy invaded by another Germanic tribe, the Lombards. They never conquer the whole peninsula; Byzantines retain control of parts of Italy from Ravenna.

774 The Franks under Charlemagne conquer the Lombard kingdom in northern Italy; Charlemagne is crowned emperor by the pope in Rome in 800.

962 The coronation in Rome by Pope John XII of Otto I of Germany as emperor marks the beginning of the Holy Roman Empire. Developments over the next three centuries are molded by the struggle for supremacy between papacy and empire, mirrored locally in the struggle between Guelphs (the papal party) and Ghibellines (supporters of the emperor).

1060–1139 The Normans conquer Sicily and southern Italy. The kingdom of Sicily, later known as Naples or the Two Sicilies, is established in 1130 and remains under Norman rule until the Hohenstaufen dynasty of Holy Roman Emperors takes over in 1179.

1300s In the absence of a strong central authority following the withdrawal of the German emperors, northern Italy fragments into a number of small but increasingly powerful city-states, notably the republics of Venice, Florence, and Genoa and the duchies of Milan, Mantua, and Savoy-Piedmont; these cities, among the most important trading and financial centers of Europe, are in the vanguard of the Renaissance, the great cultural revival of the 14th–16th centuries. Writers such as Boccaccio and Dante, artists and sculptors such as Giotto, Fra Angelico, Donatello, Raphael, and Michaelangelo, and architects such as Alberti and Brunelleschi receive patronage from the various Italian princes and dukes and transform the Italian cities and courts into the leading artistic and cultural centers of Europe.

1494–1525 In a series of wars, Valois France and Habsburg Spain, each supported by Italian allies, vie for domination of Italy. The wars end in defeat for France and also mark the decline of the city-states, which suffer major devastation and are adversely affected by the new economic conditions created by the severance of traditional land and sea routes across the Mediterranean to the east and the opening of the new Atlantic route.

1559 The Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis ends the Spanish-French wars in Italy. France gains some land, but Spain is the big winner, controlling Milan, Naples, Sicily, and Sardinia, and now dominates the Italian peninsula and the western Mediterranean. The Reformation has little effect in Italy, which remains staunchly Catholic.

1618–48 Although not directly involved in the 30 Years War, the Italian

states are caught up in the fighting as France threatens the Italian possessions of Habsburg Spain. In 1629 France threatens Mantua and in 1637 Milan. A revolt in Naples against Spanish rule in 1647 is actively supported by French troops.

1701–14 The Spanish Habsburg domination of Italy ends. After the War of the Spanish Succession its position is usurped by Habsburg Austria, which acquires Milan, Naples, Sicily, and Sardinia.

1731–48 Further readjustments between Spain and Austria give Spain control of Naples, Sicily, and Parma, and Austria control of Milan and Tuscany. Sardinia and Piedmont are united as one kingdom.

1796–97 French revolutionary forces under Napoleon Bonaparte conquer most of Italy. Napoleon redraws the country's map and absorbs Piedmont, Genoa, Tuscany, and the Papal States directly into France, and creates a kingdom of Italy in the north and Naples in the south. Sicily is now independent of Naples.

1814 After the defeat of France, the Congress of Vienna redraws the map of Italy, giving Austria control over Venice, Milan, Parma, Modena, Lucca, and Tuscany. Sardinia–Piedmont and the Papal States remain independent, while the Kingdom of the Two Sicilies gains its independence.

1831 Giuseppe Mazzini forms the Young Italy movement and becomes one of the intellectual fathers of the Risorgimento (“resurgence”), the national movement aiming for the unification of Italy. Nationalist revolts or popular uprisings against Austrian, papal, or illiberal Italian rule break out in Turin, Milan, Genoa, Modena, Parma, Naples, and many other Italian cities from 1830 onward, although all are easily crushed by authoritarian powers.

1848 In the Year of Revolutions that break out across Europe, Sardinia–Piedmont adopts a liberal constitution that is extended throughout Italy following unification.

1848–49 Nationalists rise against the Austrian rulers in the north and against the papacy. A Roman republic is established by radicals, including Giuseppe Garibaldi, but the republic is crushed by French troops called in to restore Pope Pius IX to power. In the north, nationalist troops are defeated by Austrian troops at the battle of Novara; Austria regains control of its Italian possessions.

Renaissance man

Michelangelo (left) was a painter, sculptor, architect, poet, and engineer. Along with Leonardo da Vinci, he epitomized the Italian Renaissance.

